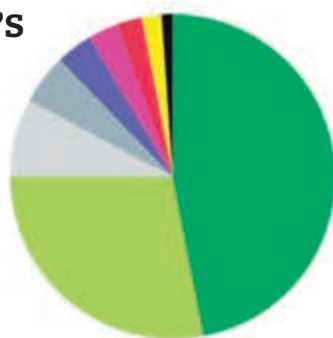


INSIDE EARTH'S CRUST

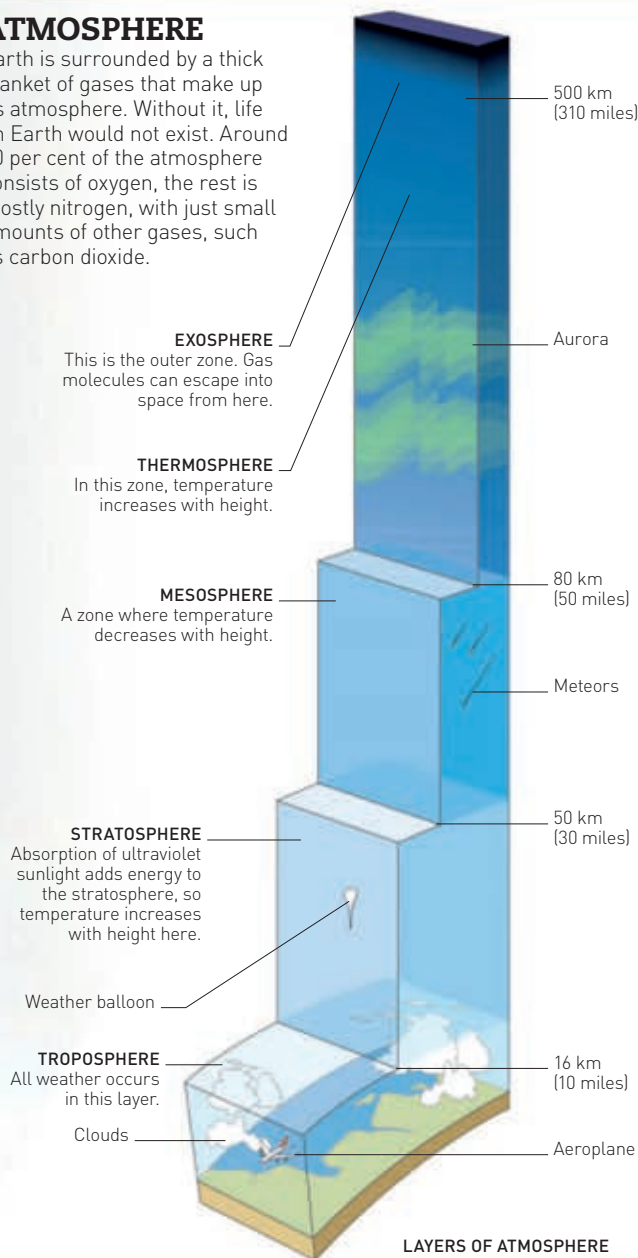
The rocky crust layer that makes up Earth's continents and ocean floors contains many different chemical elements. Most of the crust is formed of silicon dioxide, which consists of joined-together silicon and oxygen atoms.



ELEMENTS IN EARTH'S CRUST

ATMOSPHERE

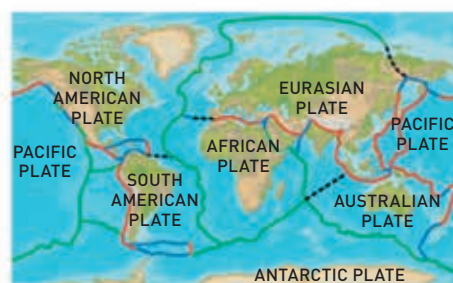
Earth is surrounded by a thick blanket of gases that make up its atmosphere. Without it, life on Earth would not exist. Around 20 per cent of the atmosphere consists of oxygen, the rest is mostly nitrogen, with just small amounts of other gases, such as carbon dioxide.



LAYERS OF ATMOSPHERE

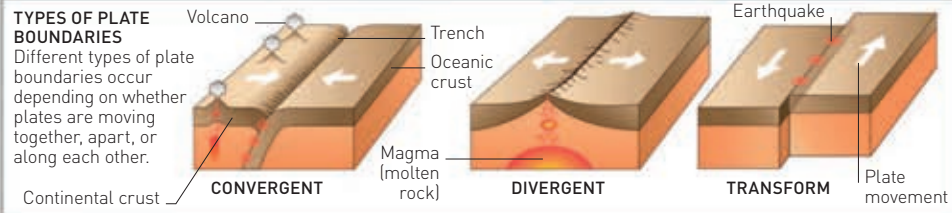
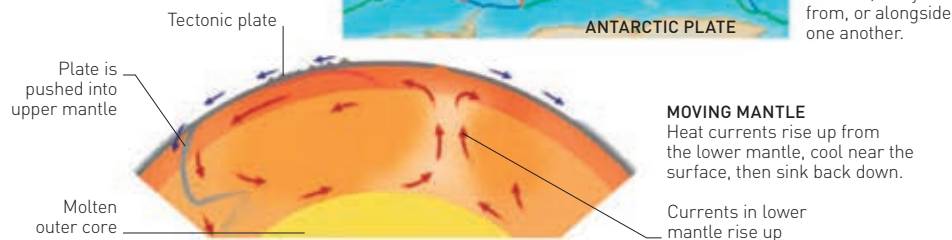
TECTONIC PLATES

Earth's crust is broken into pieces, or tectonic plates, that fit together like a jigsaw puzzle. These plates float on the mantle – solid but slowly moving rock with pockets of liquid magma. When the mantle moves, so do the plates.



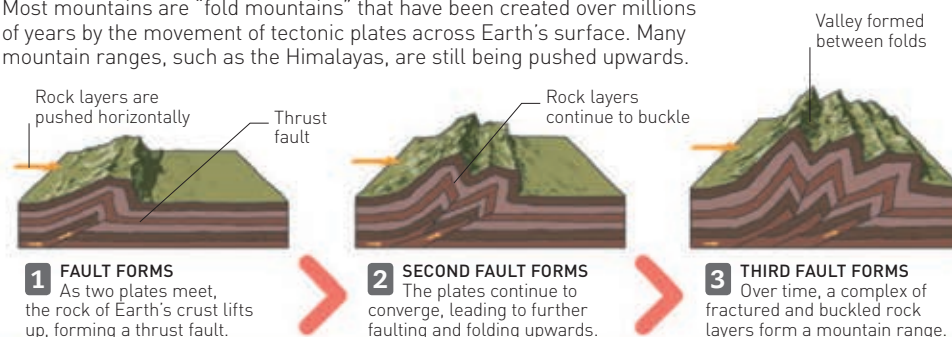
KEY
 Convergent
 Divergent
 Uncertain
 Transform

ON THE MOVE
 Earth's plates are constantly moving towards, away from, or alongside one another.



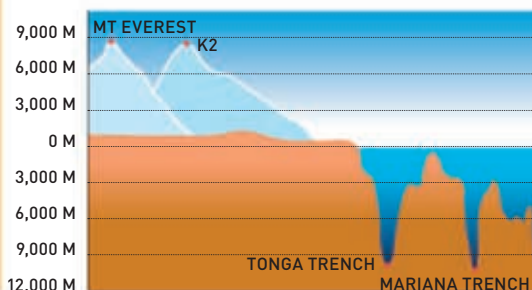
MOUNTAIN BUILDING

Most mountains are "fold mountains" that have been created over millions of years by the movement of tectonic plates across Earth's surface. Many mountain ranges, such as the Himalayas, are still being pushed upwards.



HIGHEST AND DEEPEST

At 8,848 m (29,029 ft), the top of Mount Everest, part of the Himalaya mountain range in Asia, is Earth's highest point. By contrast, the Mariana Trench, in the Pacific Ocean, is the deepest, reaching 10,920 m (35,829 ft) below sea level.



LIFE ON EARTH

More than 3.5 billion years ago, life on Earth began. Over time, it has evolved and diversified to suit its natural environment.



ARCHAEA
 A very early form of life, consisting of single cells.



BACTERIA
 Microscopic bacteria live in most habitats. Some cause diseases.



PROTISTS
 Made of single cells with nuclei, some protists can make their own food.



FUNGI
 Fungi get their nutrients from dead organic matter.



PLANTS
 Plants use sunlight to make food, and release oxygen into the air.



ANIMALS
 Animals get their food from eating other organisms.



DESERT
 With sparse rain and extreme temperatures, little life survives here.



RIVER AND WETLAND
 Despite covering less than one per cent of Earth's surface, freshwater rivers and wetland support a lot of plants and animals.



MOUNTAIN
 Wildlife is plentiful on warm, lower mountain slopes, but at higher altitudes, temperatures drop, and little can survive.



FOREST
 Forests are made up of the biggest plants on Earth – trees. They provide shelter and food to a vast array of life.